



The Samsung Digimax U-CA 3

that we tested, 32 MB was the highest available. The Kodak DX6490 and the Sony P100 had just 16MB storage, which holds more than 10 images at their highest image settings.

Battery life is also a concern with these high-end beasts. LCD screens, zoom lenses, video capture, auto-focus, all serve to drain a battery faster. Re-chargeable Li-Ion or Ni-MH batteries go quite a way to solve the problem. The Canon PowerShot A80 comes bundled with non-rechargeable alkaline batteries, even though it needs four AA batteries. It was the same case with the Samsung V5, with two AA Alkaline batteries. Sony sensibly included two AA re-chargeable Ni-MH batteries.

Bundled accessories make life easier for you. For instance, the Samsung U-CA 3 comes with a car charger which is ideal while travelling. HP bundled a separate USB cable for PictBridge compliant printers.

Except for the Kodak all other cameras were PictBridge compliant. The absence of the standard was a huge oversight on Kodak's part. Kodak cameras can be cradled on to the Kodak Printer Dock, a dye-sublimation printer, but it should have supported a standard just like the other cameras.

Were They Easy to Use?

Ergonomics is vital. A camera with tiny or ineptly-placed buttons is worth nothing at the end. The Kodak DX6490 has a jog dial to set different modes. The dial is not very easy on the fingers, as it needs good effort to just rotate it. This was the only camera to have an additional jog dial to change the exposure mode, the shutter speed or the aperture setting, without taking the camera off from the eye-level. The Canon A80 has small buttons but has enough breathing space between

them. Sony, with its rounded contour near the lens, offers an ideal design for two-hand operation.

The Kodak had the cleanest menu navigation to offer—a simple and linear style. Sony and Canon cameras display icons that will leave you rummaging the manuals several times over.

Presets are a God-send for those looking for quick and easy shooting. The Kodak DX7630 with its 16 presets including Party, Beach, Snow or Self-portrait, was one such camera.

The Sony P100 is the fastest camera of all when it comes to starting up. The moment you press the power button, the lens is in place and LCD will show the frame you have focused on, all this in no time.

How Did They Perform?

For landscape photography, the Kodak DX6490 impressed us with its superior lens. The camera managed to capture a very lively picture with depth, as well as, wide reproduction of colour tones. The Sony P100 gave an image quality as good as the Kodak DX6490, but it lacked in depth. The Sony DSC-W1 man-

aged to capture the scene clearly in overcast conditions, which is a commendable showing.

The Kodak LS743 lived up to expectations with both light and shadows clearly defined. The good news in this particular test was that none of the cameras returned an image below acceptable quality level.

Our next focus was on portrait shoots. The Sony P100 returned good skin tone as did the HP R707. The HP, however, had a flash that was unduly bright in the centre of a frame. Therefore, a portrait snap of a person with glasses needed to be taken with the camera pointing slightly upwards, or by maintaining a five to six feet distance from the subject, and then using the zoom. Both the Canons returned good skin tones. But, despite maintaining the correct distance, the subject was slightly out of focus with the Canon A80.

The Samsung U-CA 3 returned an image that was on a darker side, while a red cast was prominent on the image taken with Samsung V5.

In the motherboard shoot, the Kodak DX6490 dominated, with amazing picture quality, near-perfect colour reproduction, good small-detail reproduction, and great specular effects. The camera also reproduced smooth gradation while handling merging colour shades. The Sony P100 managed to shoot well but missed out on colour separation, as the red of the AGP slot almost merged with the red of the motherboard. The Sony showed one of the finest gradations in shades.

Despite the studio lights, the images taken by the Canon A80 turned out to be little on the darker side. None of the elements



The Kodak DX6490 captured detail as fine as tiny slots on Memory slots



Contact Sheet

Brand	Company	Telephone	E-mail	Web-site
Canon	Canon India Ltd	011-26806572	Shyam@canon.co.in	www.canon.com
Casio	J J Mehta & Sons	022-24306356	info@jjmehta.com	www.casio.com
Creative	Creative Labs Asia	9820357718	murali.krishnan@ctl.creative.com	www.creative.com
D'zign	Wespro Corporation	022-30916039	wespro@sify.com	www.dzign.com
HP	Hewlett Packard India Ltd	1600 11 4141	seema.dawar@hp.com	www.hp.com
Kodak	Neoteric Informatique	022-39828600	sales@neoteric-info.com	www.kodak.com
Nikon Coolpix 3200	J J Mehta & Sons	022-2430 6356	info@jjmehta.com	www.nikon.com
Nikon Coolpix 4100	Inter Photo India	022- 24925151	info@interphotoindia.com	www.nikon.com
Olympus	Komal International	022-22611274	indiaolympus@vsnl.net	www.olympus.com
Orite	Mediatech India	022-26361111	sales@mediatechindia.com	www.orite.com.tw
Premier	Wespro Corporation	022-30916039	wespro@sify.com	-
Samsung	Samsung India Electronics Ltd	011-51511234	sales@samsungindia.com	www.samsung.com
Sony	Sony India Ltd	1600 1111 88	singhr@sid.in.sony.com.sg	www.sony.com